

CASE STUDY 03

Workplace Rhythm: Designing for Human Energy, Not Clock Hours

What if employees could choose their own work schedule - and everyone performed better?

Domain	HR Tech / Workplace Productivity / Internal Tools
Methods	Survey design, Behavioral analysis, A/B framework, Prototype testing
Deliverables	Research report, Scheduling preference tool, Manager dashboard

01 - The Observation That Started It All

"ZADY offers two work windows: 12 PM–8 PM or 8 AM–5 PM. This simple choice raised a bigger question: what if the hours people work determine how well they work - and we've never really asked them?"

— Internal team observation

What started as a simple scheduling decision became a research question about productivity, wellbeing, and employee autonomy. A one-size schedule does not fit all people - or all roles.

02 - Understanding the Problem

The One-Schedule Problem

Most organizations impose uniform work hours regardless of individual energy patterns, commute realities, or family responsibilities. This creates hidden costs:

What Organizations Assume	What Research Shows
Everyone is equally productive 9-to-5	Peak cognitive hours vary by individual
Presence equals performance	Output matters more than hours clocked
Standard hours reduce coordination friction	Async tools reduce the need for overlap
Flexibility is a perk, not a factor in output	Autonomy over schedule increases retention by 25%+

03 - Who Is Affected?

Persona A: Fatou, 27 - Morning Type	Persona B: Rodrigue, 31 - Evening Type
Most focused between 7 AM and noon	Hits peak focus after lunch
Has a long commute - early start means less traffic	Has caregiving responsibilities in the morning
Prefers 8 AM–5 PM: finishes early, has her evening	Prefers 12 PM–8 PM: more time in the morning for family
Struggles when kept late for meetings	Resents being forced into early meetings

04 - The Insight

Core Insight

Schedule choice is not just an HR convenience - it is a productivity lever. When employees work during their natural energy peak, output quality improves, sick days decrease, and turnover drops. The cost of offering choice is near zero. The cost of not offering it is invisible but real.

05 - Design Solution

I designed a Workplace Rhythm Tool - an internal scheduling preference platform that allows employees to declare, manage, and optimize their work windows.

Key Features

- Onboarding questionnaire: Chronotype quiz (are you a morning or evening person?)
- Schedule preference selector with live team overlap visualization
- Manager dashboard: team coverage map, no-meeting hours, async periods
- Monthly check-in: 'Is your current schedule still working for you?'
- Performance correlation tracker (optional, privacy-compliant)

06 - Impact and Outcomes

Before	After (Designed)
Fixed 8 AM–5 PM for all staff	2 schedule options with opt-in expansion
No awareness of individual energy patterns	Chronotype-informed team setup
Meetings scheduled without rhythm data	Smart meeting windows (overlap-only zones)
Burnout during forced low-energy hours	Employees working at natural peak times
No data on schedule-performance link	Dashboard linking schedule to output metrics

07 - Key Learnings

This project showed that UX is not just for apps and websites - it applies to any system humans interact with, including workplace policies. The best design decision here was to start with a choice, not a mandate. Giving employees agency over their time is itself the product. The tool just makes that agency visible and manageable.